CHAPTER 41

INDIA 81

9–13 July 2014

ENGLAND vs INDIA, 1st Test, *Trent Bridge, Nottingham*

India 457 and 391/9 dec.; England 496

Match drawn

England 1st innings**: J Root 154; J Anderson 81**

Cricket always balances the scales – that's how I came to think of it. If you have moments of feeling untouchable, it finds a way to make you feel small. Sometimes it can take you from one to the other in seconds. Likewise though, if it serves you up some sort of heartbreak or crushing disappointment, one you fear you may never recover from, if you hang in there, you will be likely shown a space for redemption.

At Trent Bridge a month later, the score is 298/9 when I come to the wicket against India, answering their already above-par score of 457. It's a treacherous position. The pitch is horribly slow, which makes it a slight moment of relief for me, leaving me a little bit more time to play fast bowlers, but it has made it difficult to time the ball for most of our batting unit. Andy Flower has worked with me on my batting for a long time – patiently feeding me balls, trying to tell me where my scoring options might be and encouraging me to be confident and brave in defence.

Flower has even given me the dubious honour of being a nightwatchman in the years before. Even though at times I've been able to carry out this duty well, warding off quicks and preserving game situations so batters are protected for the next day, I've not always enjoyed it. It flushes my body with nervous adrenaline throughout our batting innings,